

Reclaiming Slurs Over Apparent Time

Nat Hansen & Shen-yi Liao

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A Former Slur Is Reclaimed, And Listeners Have Mixed Feelings

AUGUST 21, 2019 · 10:33 AM ET

By [Juliette Rocheleau](#)

As language shifts, terms take on new meanings. But when is it appropriate for media organizations to reflect those changes?

In recent years, the word "queer" has been increasingly seen and heard in NPR reporting, upsetting some listeners. One listener from Illinois wrote, "I am a gay man and I did not spend my entire life being called queer as a slur for journalists to accept it as reclaimed. It isn't." Another listener wrote to us from



People celebrating Gay Pride in Reykjavik, Iceland.
Arctic-Images/Getty Images

The Q-word today

The word "queer" today is found widely in NPR reporting, but comfort levels with the word vary among NPR journalists. For some, the hesitancy seems to stem from the fear that it will unintentionally offend. Many times, the apprehensions follow generational lines, DeRose said.

"It is quite often a generational issue where younger people — millennials — are more fine with it. Gen Xers like myself are somewhat OK with it. Some you might find in each category," said DeRose. "And then older people or boomers, maybe, who find it problematic."

DeRose's explanation echoes the sentiments of a 71-year-old listener from California who wrote, "The usage of 'queer' is simply painful." He continued, "A more judicious use of a word viewed as pejorative to many or most (at least in my age cohort) is in order."

Theoretical Background

Slur Reclamation

- Slur reclamation has attracted a lot of interest from philosophers (Anderson 2018; Cepollaro & López de Sa 2022; Jeshion 2020; Popa-Wyatt 2020; Ritchie 2017; Zyglewicz in press).
- There is agreement that some slurs have been reclaimed, to different degrees. How exactly do we know that they have, and to what degree?
- Despite the level of interest in the topic, quantitative studies of slur reclamation are surprisingly rare (one exception is Edmonson 2021).

Slur Reclamation

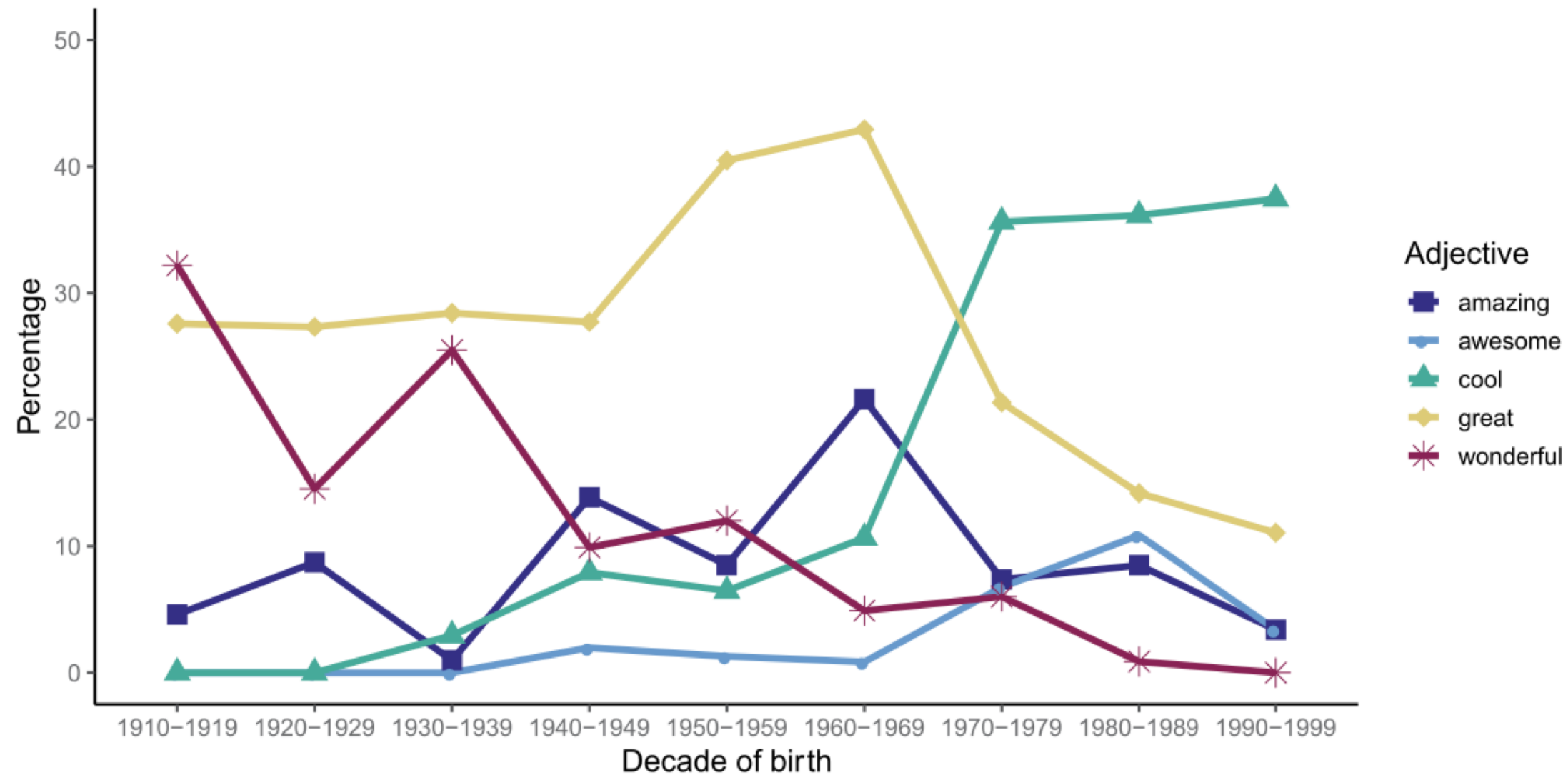
- A characteristic feature of slur reclamation is the **reduction of negative valence over time**. (See Edmondson 2021, 212)
- Two plausible candidates of slurs that have been reclaimed are ‘queer’ (Brontsema 2004) and ‘slut’ (Herbert 2015).
- Results from two empirical studies (reported in Hansen and Liao in press) using an *apparent time* method show that these two terms, in their adjectival forms, exhibit this characteristic feature.

Language Change Over Time

- In an ideal world, we would conduct a *real time* longitudinal study that tracked the way a group of speakers over time, or different samples from a population at different times, use 'queer' and see if it shows signs of meaning change.

Language Change Over (Apparent) Time

- In an ideal world, we would conduct a *real time* longitudinal study that tracked the way a group of speakers over time, or different samples from a population at different times, use ‘queer’ and see if it shows signs of meaning change.
- In this non-ideal world, we conducted *apparent time* studies that assume “linguistic differences among different generations of a population (apparent-time differences) would mirror actual diachronic developments in the language (real-time linguistic changes)” (Bailey 2004: 313).



Tagliamonte 2020

Empirical Evidence

Measuring Conceptual Inflation: the Case of 'Racist'

Nat Hansen & Shen-yi Liao

Ergo: An Open Access Journal of Philosophy (forthcoming) [Copy](#) [BibTeX](#)

Abstract

Is the term 'racist' being applied so widely that it is losing its moral force? Theorists and pundits from across the political spectrum think that it is. They call such a change of meaning "conceptual inflation" and argue that we should try to stop it by restricting the use of 'racist' or replacing 'racist' with new expressions. But what evidence do we have that 'racist' is inflated? Economists do not track currency inflation with mere vibes; they use measurements such as the consumer price index. For example, using CPI, it is observable that there has been considerable US dollar inflation over the last three decades or so: \$1.00 in 1989 has the purchasing power of \$2.54 in 2024. If 'racist' has undergone a similar transformation, as critics of conceptual inflation contend, how could that be measured? Before plunging into the normative debate about whether conceptual inflation is good or bad, we should gather systematic empirical evidence about whether the purported conceptual inflation of 'racist' is in fact happening. That is what we do in this paper: we use an apparent time study, a technique drawn from sociolinguistics, to measure whether 'racist' is undergoing conceptual inflation. An apparent time study looks at the linguistic behavior of people of different ages as a way of measuring linguistic variation over time. We distinguish two processes that constitute conceptual inflation: extension expansion and intensity bleaching. Across three studies, we found some equivocal evidence that 'racist' has undergone extension expansion—its reference class may have slightly expanded—but no evidence that it has undergone intensity bleaching—its moral force remains the same. By comparing 'racist' with other terms that have plausibly undergone meaning change, like 'queer', we argue that claims about the conceptual inflation of 'racist', as they are standardly understood, are overblown.



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Measuring Conceptual Inflation: The Case of 'Racist' [Study 2]

Contributors: [Shen-yi Liao](#), [Nathaniel Hansen](#)

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Measuring Conceptual Inflation: The Case of 'Racist' [Study 3]

Contributors: [Shen-yi Liao](#), [Nathaniel Hansen](#)

Study 2 (from Hansen & Liao in press)

- We intentionally recruited two age cohorts that are at least three decades apart, the *under-30s* and the *over-60s*, and did not attempt to achieve representativeness on other demographic dimensions.
- *Under-30s* — $n = 194$, 49.11%; $M_{age} = 25.13$, $SD_{age} = 3.45$; 46.3% men, 48.4% women, 5.3% non-binary; 54.5% white, 44.85% nonwhite; $M_{political} = 27.63$, $SD_{political} = 25.82$; 15.5% some high school, 69.1% some undergraduate, 15.5% some postgraduate
- *Over-60s* — $n = 193$, 48.86%; $M_{age} = 65.54$, $SD_{age} = 4.86$; 33.9% men, 65.6% women, 0.5% non-binary; 89.6% white, 10.36% nonwhite; $M_{political} = 35.78$, $SD_{political} = 31.96$; 9.3% some high school, 66.3% some undergraduate, 24.4% some postgraduate

Study 2 (from Hansen & Liao in press)

Two blocks in counterbalanced randomized order, on a scale of 0-100:

[intensity]

How bad is it for a person to be called ‘____’?

[extension]

What % of people can be reasonably called ‘____’?

In each block, in counterbalanced randomized order:

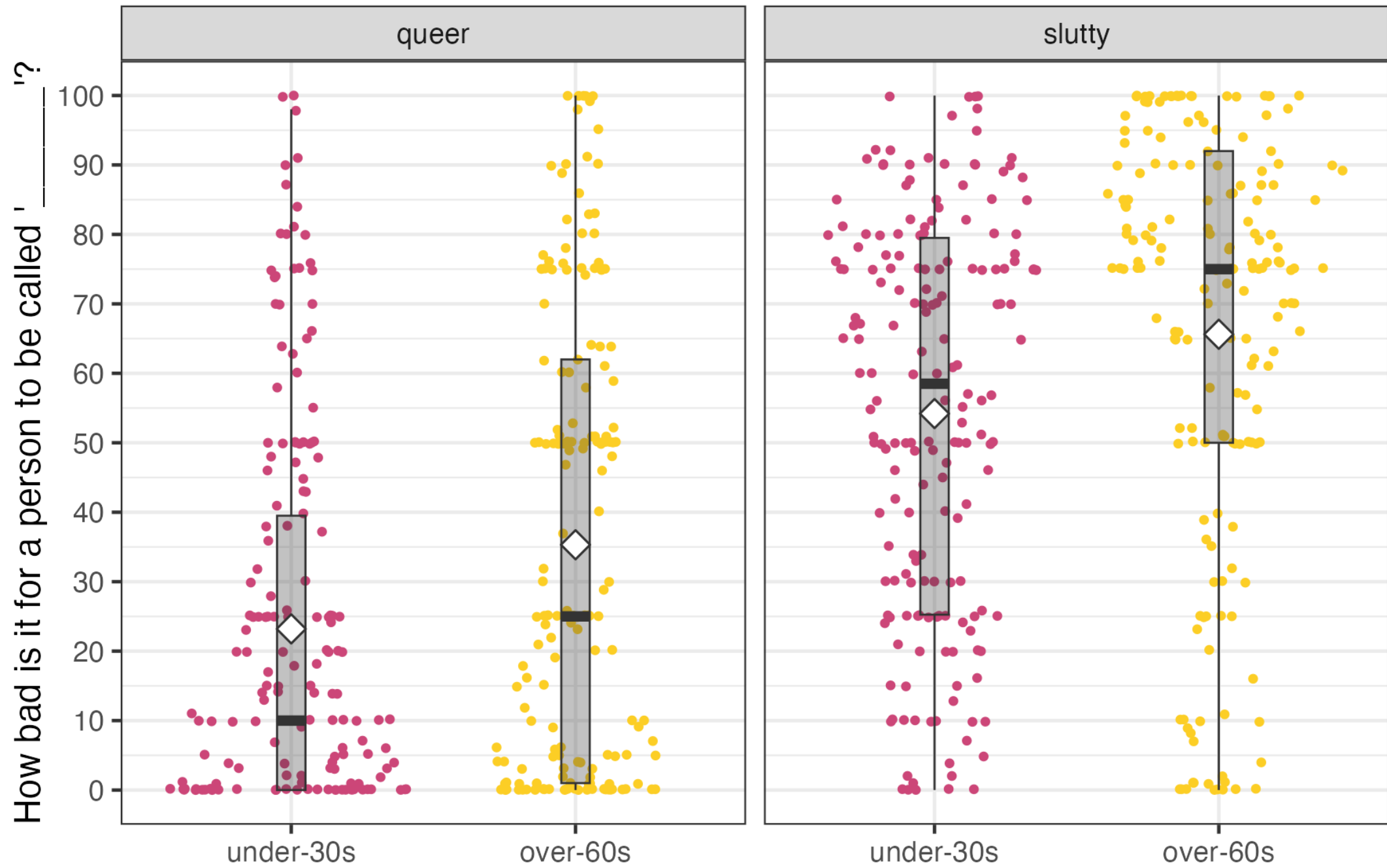
[target term]

‘racist’

[reclaimed(?) terms]

‘queer’, ‘slutty’, ‘neurodivergent’

Finally, demographic questions about age, gender, race, education level, and political orientation.



Reclaiming Slurs Over (Apparent) Time

- **‘Queer’** — The perceived valence difference between the two age cohorts ($M_{\text{under-30s}} = 23.20$, $M_{\text{over-60s}} = 35.32$) is negative, statistically significant, and small (*difference* = -12.12, 95% CI [-18.48, -5.75], $t(371.76) = -3.74$, $p < .001$; Cohen’s $d = -0.38$, 95% CI [-0.58, -0.18]).
- **‘Slutty’** — The perceived valence difference between the two age cohorts ($M_{\text{under-30s}} = 54.20$, $M_{\text{over-60s}} = 65.62$) is negative, statistically significant, and small (*difference* = -11.42, 95% CI [-17.67, -5.17], $t(382.05) = -3.59$, $p < .001$; Cohen’s $d = -0.37$, 95% CI [-0.57, -0.16]).

Study 3 (from Hansen & Liao in press)

- N = 398 (no exclusions)
- Demo (age, race, gender) representative US sample via Prolific
- Age — $M = 45.50$, $SD = 15.49$
- Race — 62.6% white, 27.4% nonwhite
- Gender — 48.5% men, 49.1% women, 2.4% nonbinary
- No experimental manipulation. Everyone was asked all questions

Study 3 (from Hansen & Liao in press)

Two blocks in counterbalanced randomized order, on a scale of 0-100:

[intensity]

How bad is it for a person to be called ‘____’?

[extension]

What % of people can be reasonably called ‘____’?

In each block, in counterbalanced randomized order:

[target term]

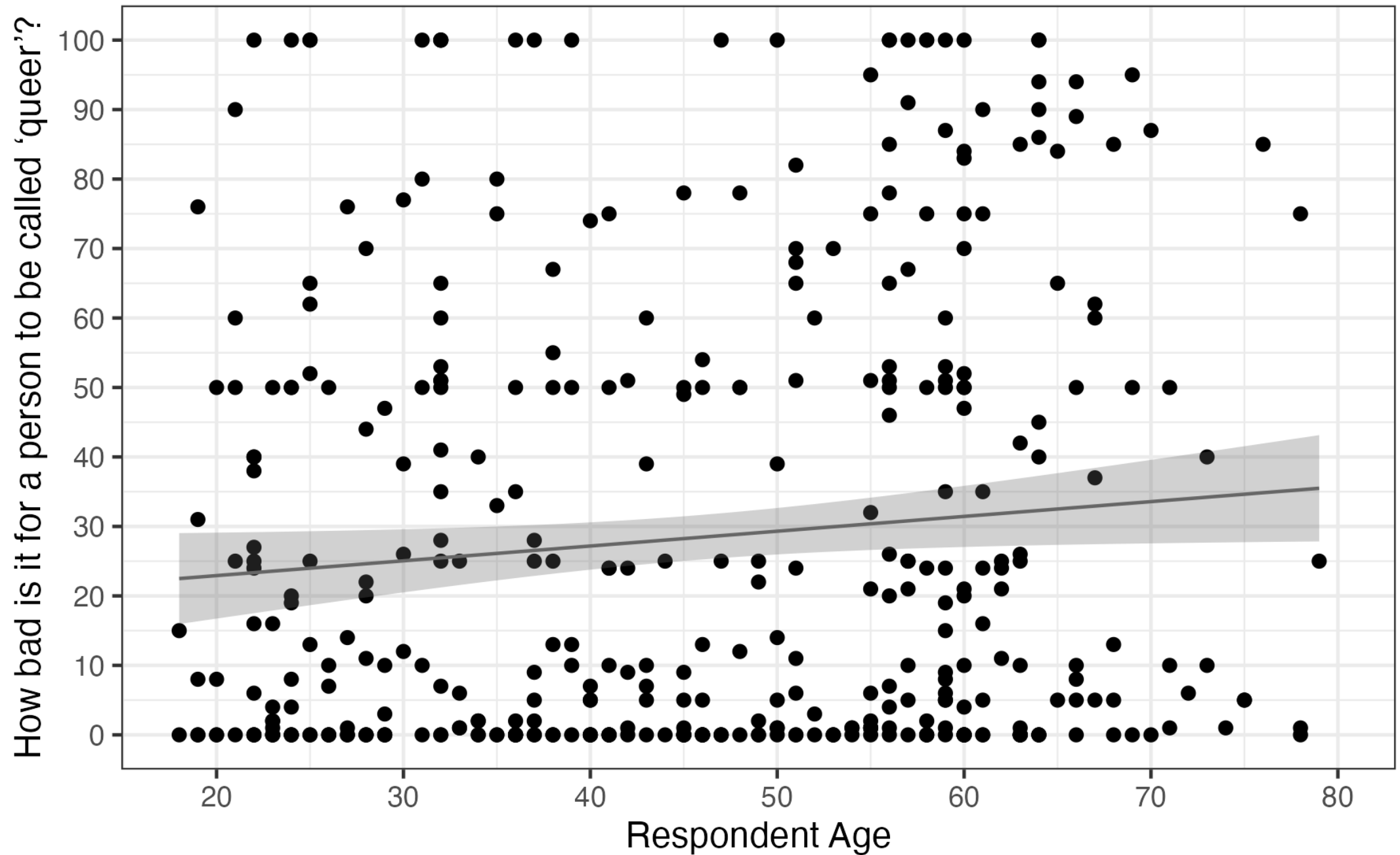
‘racist’

[reclaimed(?) terms]

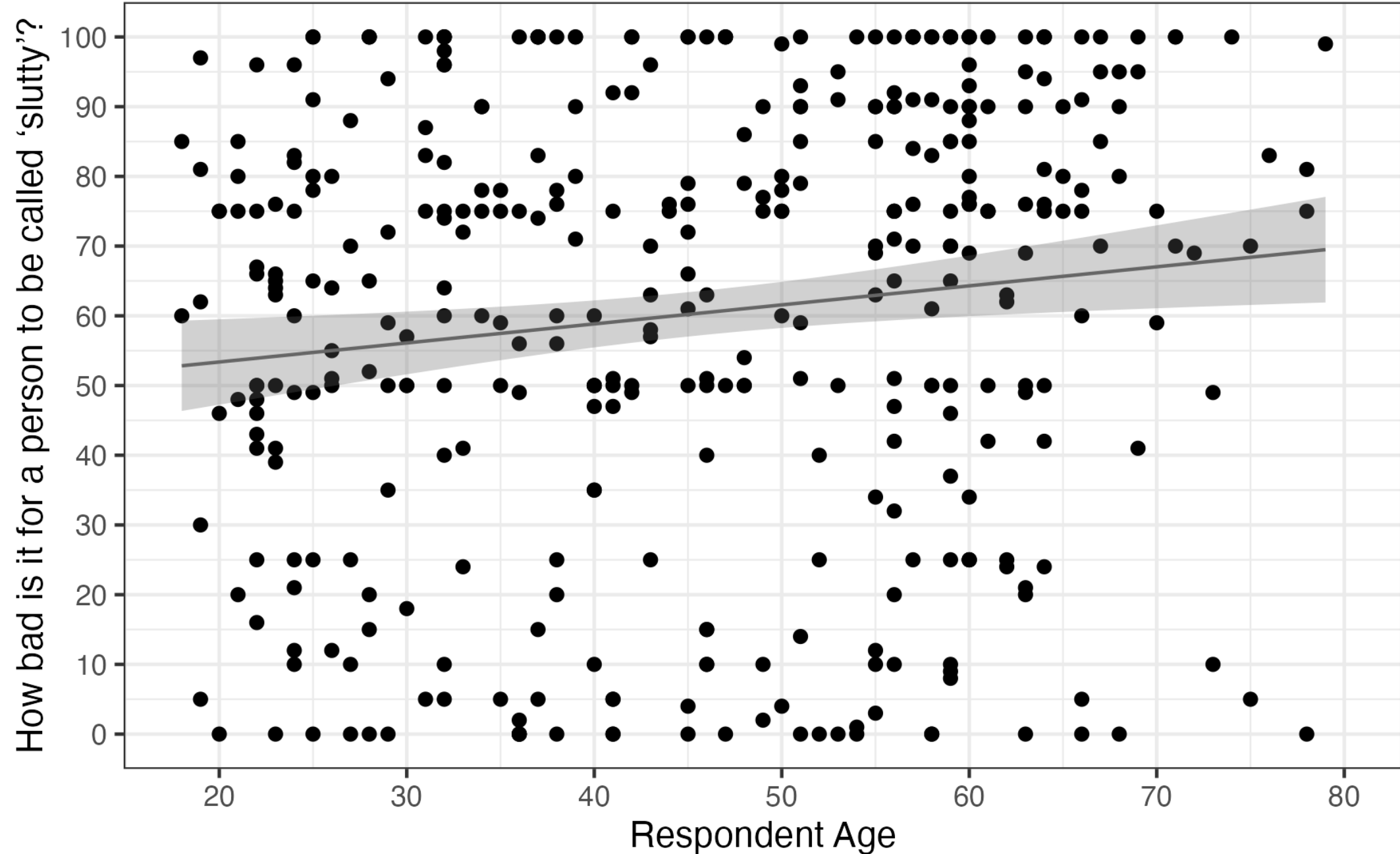
‘queer’, ‘slutty’, ‘neurodivergent’

Finally, demographic questions about age, gender, race, education level, and political orientation.

Negative Valence of 'Queer'



Negative Valence of 'Slutty'

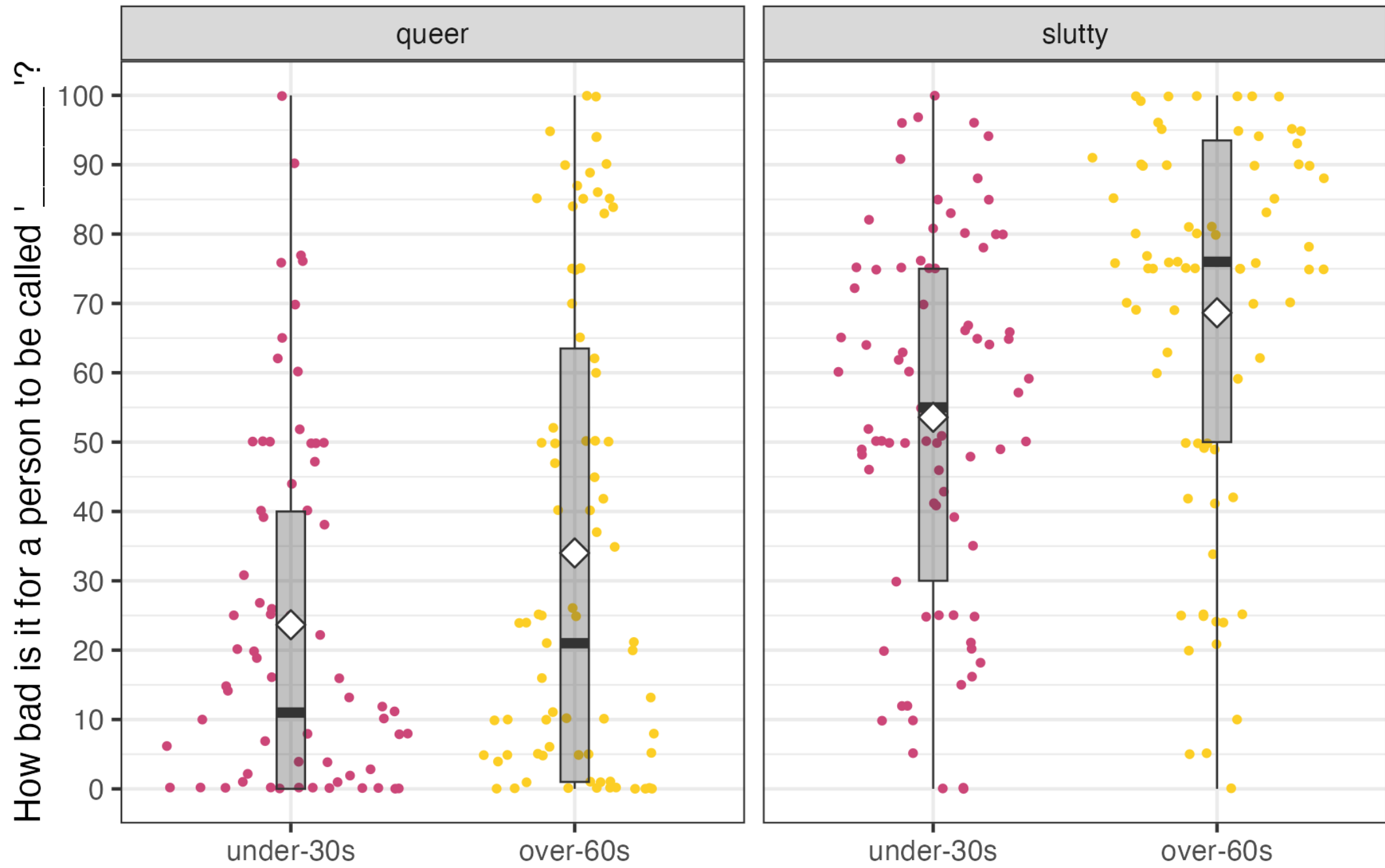


Reclaiming Slurs Over (Apparent) Time

- **‘Queer’** — The correlation between perceived valence and respondent age is positive, statistically significant, and small ($r = 0.10$, 95% CI [2.45e-03, 0.20], $t(387) = 2.01$, $p = 0.045$).
- **‘Slutty’** — The correlation between perceived valence and respondent age is positive, statistically significant, and small ($r = 0.13$, 95% CI [0.03, 0.23], $t(387) = 2.61$, $p = 0.009$).

Study 3 (from Hansen & Liao in press)

- We can also (as in Study 2) examine two age cohorts that are at least three decades apart, the *under-30s* and the *over-60s*, to bring out any change over (apparent) time that exists.
- *Under-30s* — $n = 85$; $M_{age} = 24.25$, $SD_{age} = 3.20$; 48.8% men, 46.2% women, 5.0% non-binary; 50.6% nonwhite; $M_{political} = 35.56$, $SD_{political} = 29.45$; 29.4% some high school, 61.2% some undergraduate, 9.4% some postgraduate
- *Over-60s* — $n = 87$; $M_{age} = 65.22$, $SD_{age} = 5.07$; 52.4% men, 46.4% women, 1.2% non-binary; 17.2% nonwhite; $M_{political} = 40.57$, $SD_{political} = 29.62$; 18.4% some high school, 54.0% some undergraduate, 27.6% some postgraduate



Reclaiming Slurs Over (Apparent) Time

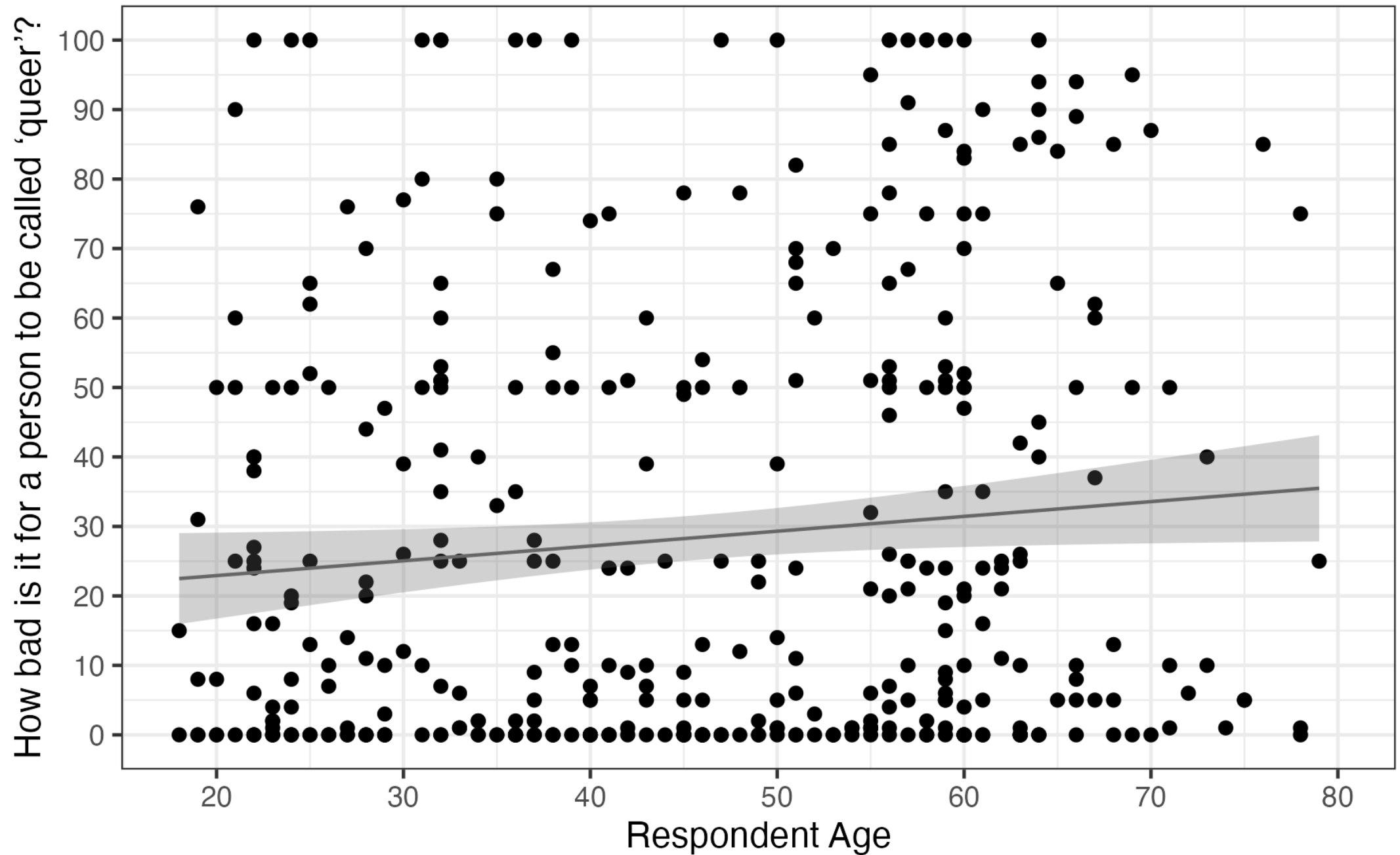
- **‘Queer’** — The perceived valence difference between the two age cohorts ($M_{\text{under-30s}} = 23.66$, $M_{\text{over-60s}} = 34.01$) is negative, statistically significant, and small (*difference* = -10.35, 95% CI [-20.01, -0.70], $t(165.90) = -2.12$, $p = .036$; Cohen’s $d = -0.32$, 95% CI [-0.62, -0.02]).
- **‘Slutty’** — The perceived valence difference between the two age cohorts ($M_{\text{under-30s}} = 53.58$, $M_{\text{over-60s}} = 68.64$) is negative, statistically significant, and medium (*difference* = -15.07, 95% CI [-24.01, -6.13], $t(169.99) = -3.33$, $p = .001$; Cohen’s $d = -0.51$, 95% CI [-0.81, -0.20]).

Other Thoughts

Application Range?

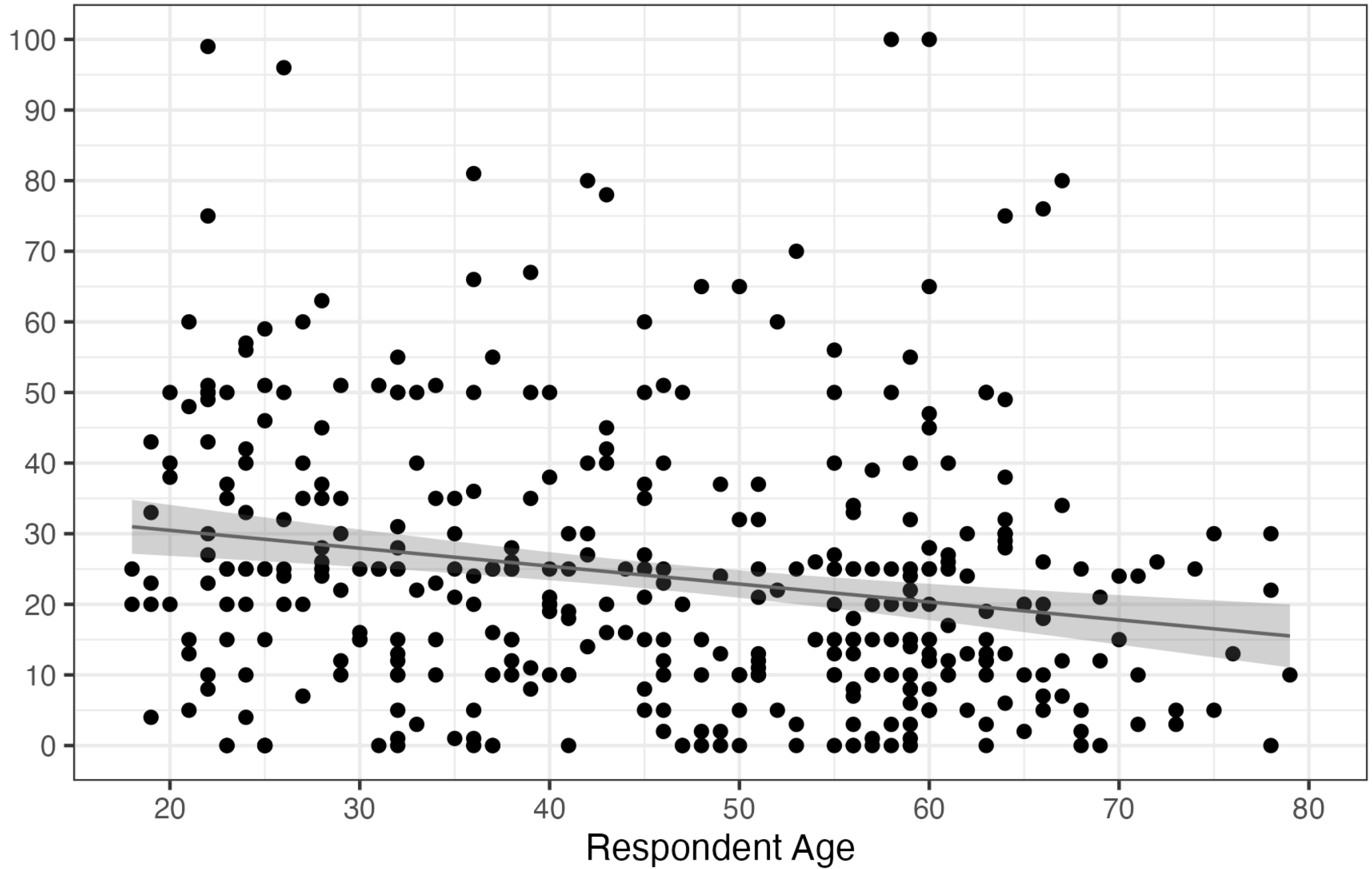
- In addition, we consider whether there is an inverse correlation between a reclaimed slur's negative valence and its application range.
- We find mixed results: there does appear to be such an inverse correlation **at the apparent time level**, but there does not appear to be such a relationship at the **individual level**.
- To illustrate, we present results concerning 'queer' from Study 3.

Negative Valence of 'Queer'

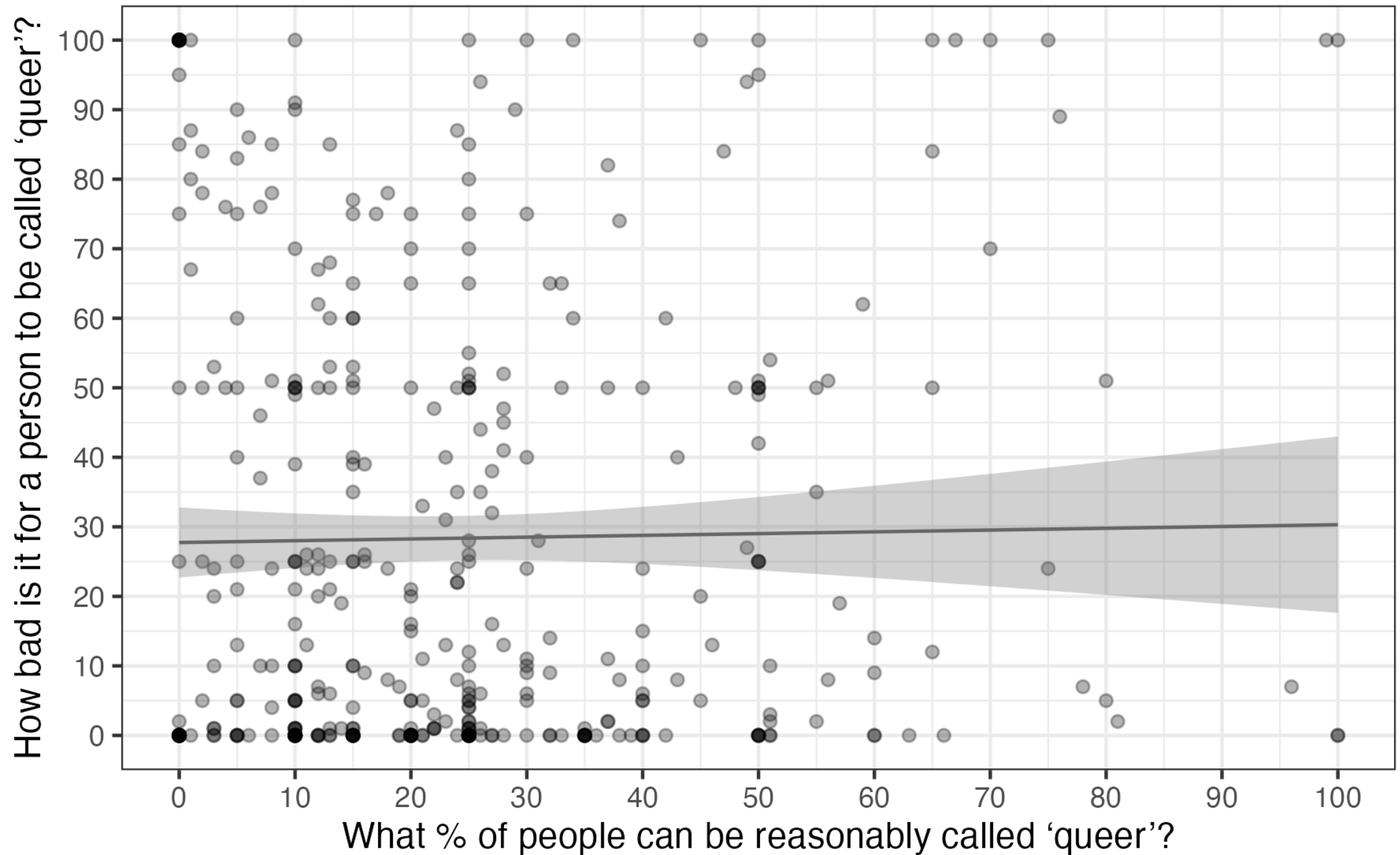


Application Range of 'Queer'

What % of people can be reasonably called 'queer'?



Negative Valence vs. Application Range of 'Queer'



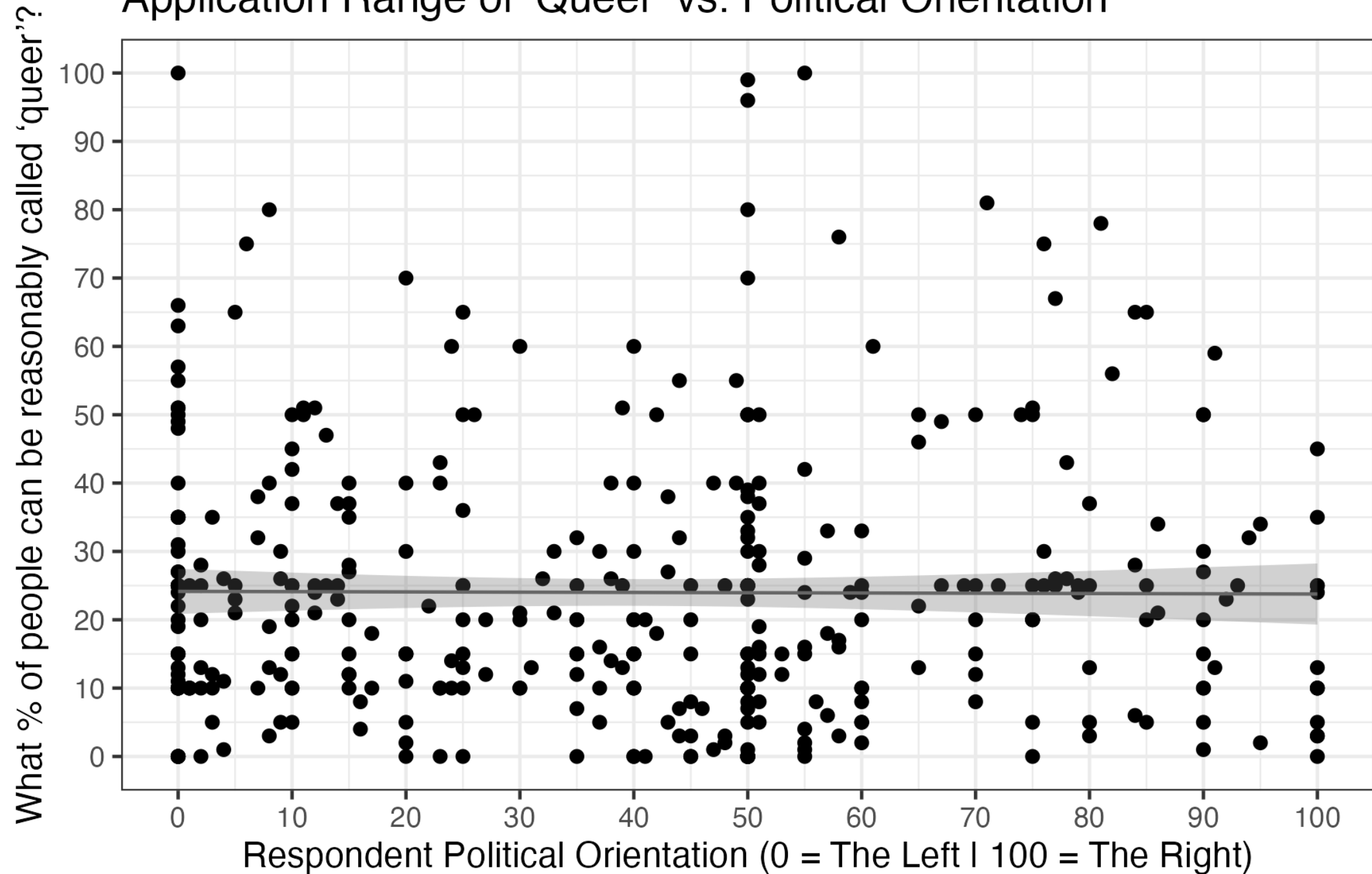
Neutral Counterpart?

- Slur reclamation can result in the coexistence of (at least) two valences of the same term in natural language (Zyglewicz in press).
- For example, even nowadays ‘queer’ can still be used with its slurry negative valence and with its neutral valence. If valences are part of a term’s sense, then successful slur reclamation can create a homonymous *neutral counterpart* of a slur (see Falbo 2021: sec 2–3 for an overview).

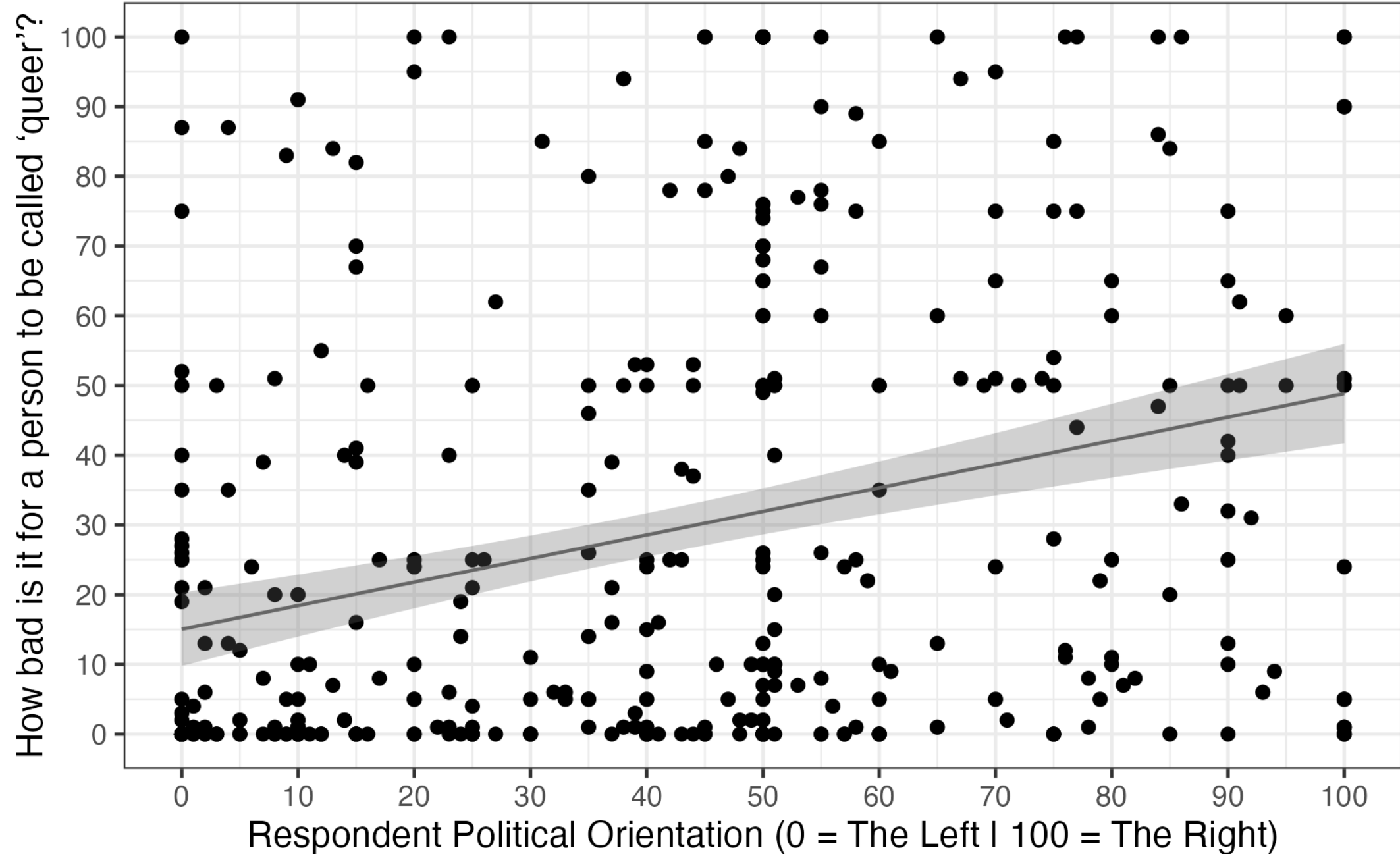
Neutral Counterpart?

- Indeed, with 'queer', we found that political liberals and political conservatives **agree on its application range**, but **disagree about its negative valence**.
- The fact that we did not find negative valence to be inversely correlated with the application range at the individual level suggests that the extension of a term can come apart from its pejorative force, consistent with the existence of neutral counterparts.

Application Range of 'Queer' vs. Political Orientation



Negative Valence of 'Queer' vs. Political Orientation



Free Ideas?

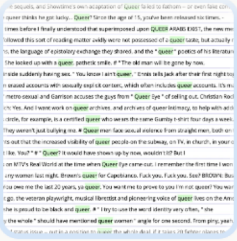
Ideas for Future Studies?

How should we follow up? What studies would you like to see?

- Reviewer 1: Does linguistic change with slurs happen more quickly due to the attention that they receive?
- Reviewer 2: Could some speakers use 'queer' as synonymous with 'weird' and thus have different neutral counterparts in mind?
- Other terms: 'autistic'? What else?
- Using linguistic corpora and LLM-automated classification?

Tales of the City, its Showtime sequels, and Showtime's own adaptation of **Queer** failed to fathom -- or even fake convincingly. In America, we get a . You like it? If you're some queer thinks he got lucky... **Queer**? Since the age of 15, you've been released six times. - EXIST. " I re-read it several times before I finally understood that superimposed upon **QUEER** ARABS EXIST, the new message, in coupling the word preached that those who followed this sort of reading-matter avidly were not possessed of a **queer** taste, but actually represented a higher type o his homosocial companions, the language of epistolary exchange they shared, and the " **queer** " poetics of his literature -- particularly his 1764-65 Oh, it was fair to kill him! " She looked up with a **queer**, pathetic smile. # " The old man will be gone by now, night on a distant mountainside suddenly having sex. " You know I ain't **queer**, " Ennis tells Jack after their first night together. " Me, neither 's recent Adult Content ban erased accounts with sexually explicit content, which often includes **queer** accounts. It's made worse considering the ' because he doesn't " feel " metro-sexual and Garrison accuses the guys from " **Queer** Eye " of selling out. Christian Rock Hard Original Air Date: being " saved. " # Cvetkovich: Yes. And I want work on **queer** archives, and archives of queer intimacy, to help with addressing the legacies of # The guy in charge of this circle, for example, is a certified **queer** who wears the same Gumby t-shirt four days a week. His name is Denis check if I would get hard? They weren't just bullying me. # **Queer** men face sexual violence from straight men, both on the street and as part " (2009, 5-6). Stockton points out that the increased visibility of **queer** people-on the subway, on TV, in church, in your own family-is changing . Never seen a cock I didn't like. You? " # " **Queer**? It would have shown up by now, wouldn't it? But I KARAMO BROWN # " I was on MTV's Real World at the time when **Queer** Eye came out. I remember the first time I won an award, I . I didn't see you talking to any women last night. Brown's **queer** for Capobianco. Fuck you. Fuck you. See? BROWN: Busting my a goddamn thing, Ruthie. You owe me the last 20 years, ya **queer**. You want me to prove to you I'm not queer? You want for hagiographic treatment go, the veteran playwright, musical librettist and pioneering voice of **queer** lives on the American stage is certainly not using. " # Now, Boyd says she is proud to be black and **queer**. # " I try to use the word identity very often, " she The Straights. # (I don't buy the whole " should have mentioned **queer** women " angle for one second. From piny, yeah, but everyone else if you let settlements -- a final status issue -- put in a position to **queer** the whole deal. If it takes 20 fighter planes to make sure Netanyahu shows

COCA sample for ‘queer’



NH

Classify these uses of "queer" according to negative, positive, or neutral uses

I'll analyze the various uses of "queer" in these text excerpts and classify them according to negative, positive, or neutral connotations.

Classification of "queer" usage in the provided text

Positive uses

- "QUEER ARABS EXIST" - Used as an affirming identity statement
- "queer" poetics of his literature - Describing literary style positively
- "queer archives, and archives of queer intimacy" - Used in context of preserving history
- "queer who wears the same Gumby t-shirt" - Neutral-to-positive self-identifier
- "proud to be black and queer" - Clearly positive self-identification

Neutral uses

- "queer accounts" - Descriptive of content type
- "queer people-on the subway, on TV" - Descriptive of visibility
- "queer lives on the American stage" - Descriptive of representation